Ford Motor Company

October 2001

Firestone Wilderness AT Tire Program.

Ford Motor Company has decided to replace all Firestone Wilderness AT tires (15-, 16-, and 17-inch) on Ford Motor Company products as a precautionary measure aimed at preventing potential tire failures from occurring in the future. Our records indicate that your vehicle may have Firestone Wilderness AT tires as either original equipment or replacement tires.

Why We Are Replacing These Tires.

This replacement program is both a voluntary and precautionary action. We made the decision to take this action after extensive examination of real-world data, laboratory and track testing, and consultations with the U. S. Department of Transportation's National Highway Traffic Safety Administration (NHTSA).

These efforts, in conjunction with our testing and statistical analyses, have revealed that Firestone Wilderness AT tires have a significantly lower failure rate than the tires recalled in the Summer of 2000 and that the age of the tire has a considerable impact upon its performance. However, our analyses also indicated that some Firestone Wilderness AT tires, particularly older tires, have elevated failure rates compared to other tires.

These failures include possible tire tread separation, in which the outer steel belt and/or tread of the tire separates and may become totally detached from the rest of the tire. Tire tread separation could potentially result in loss of vehicle control and/or a crash. Because Ford Motor Company does not have sufficient confidence in the future performance of these tires as they age, we're acting now in the interest of your safety and to maintain your continued trust and confidence.

How This Program Differs From Last Year's Recall.

Last year (Summer 2000), Firestone implemented a safety recall to replace certain 15-inch Wilderness AT and Radial ATX tires due to elevated failure rates. At the time of the Firestone recall, Ford Motor Company established an early warning system and continued to analyze real-world data.

Recent real-world data from Firestone revealed that failure rates are beginning to increase for some of the Wilderness AT tires. We view these findings as early warning signs that we cannot ignore. That is why Ford Motor Company is now voluntarily replacing the Firestone Wilderness AT tires on your Ford F-150 truck, free of charge.

Bridgestone/Firestone's Tire Recall Announcement Does Not Change Ford's Replacement Program.

Our program to replace all 15-,16-, and 17-inch Wilderness AT tires is not changed by Bridgestone/Firestone's recently announced expanded safety recall. Ford Motor Company will continue to replace your Wilderness AT tires at no cost to you. On October 4, NHTSA requested that Bridgestone/Firestone expand the Firestone tire safety recall announced in August 2000. Bridgestone/Firestone has agreed to comply with NHTSA's request and recall Wilderness AT P235/75 R15 and P255/70 R16 tires produced before May 1998. These Firestone Wilderness AT tires were already included in our May 2001 announcement.

Our strong recommendation is that you have your Wilderness AT tires replaced by your local participating Ford Dealer as soon as possible. NHTSA also stated that since Bridgestone/Firestone made changes to the Wilderness AT tires in May 1998, and because tread separations rarely occur in these tires before three years, the government would continue to monitor the performance of these tires, which are not included in the safety recall. Meanwhile, we stand by our original action taken in May 2001 and will not use Wilderness AT tires in Ford's tire replacement program. Ford Motor Company is committed to voluntarily replacing all 15-, 16-, and 17-inch Firestone Wilderness AT tires on our vehicles at no cost to you.

What We Are Asking You To Do.

Before doing anything else, check the tires that are now on your vehicle, including the spare tire. If you have Firestone Wilderness AT tires, they should be replaced. If you DO NOT have Firestone Wilderness AT tires on your vehicle, ARE NOT seeking a refund, or have changed your address, please complete and mail the enclosed postcard.

To have your tires replaced, please contact your local Ford Dealer for an appointment as soon as possible and prior to the program expiration date of March 31, 2002. Our dealers are committed to providing you with quality tires, professional service, and customer-friendly hours of operation.

What Ford Motor Company And Your Dealer Will Do For You.

Your Ford Dealer will replace the Firestone Wilderness AT tires on your vehicle, free of charge. However, if you have paid to have your tires replaced because of concern about the safety of your Firestone Wilderness AT tires between August 1, 2000, and the date of this letter, you may be eligible for a refund. See your local Ford Dealer for complete refund details.

Tire Maintenance.

You can help to reduce the risk of any type of tire failure by maintaining proper tire pressure. For specifications, refer to the vehicle certification label located in the driver's door opening. You should also avoid overloading your vehicle and always observe posted speeds.

If You Have Questions.

If you have further questions regarding this program, please call us toll-free at **1-866-300-1226**, from 8 a.m. to 11 p.m. EST, seven days a week; or e-mail us at tireinquiry@ford.com. For the latest information on-line, go to www.ford.com.

We thank you for your attention to this important matter. Maintaining your safety, your satisfaction, and your trust is our top priority.

Sincerely,



Ann O'Neill
Director
Vehicle Service and Programs